

"I always check my surroundings, but there are times when you don't pay attention."

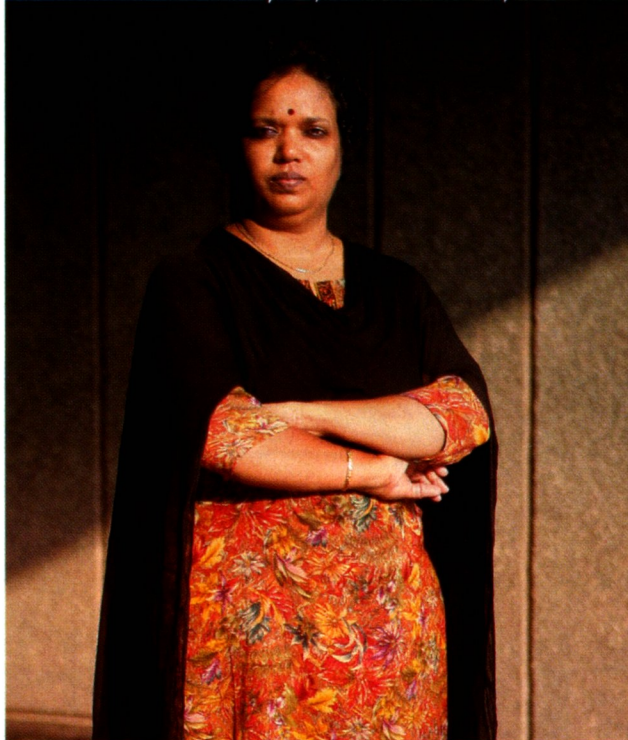
The year was 1998. It was late at night, probably 10 p.m. I had just parked my car outside my home in Delhi's Vasant Kunj when I saw someone move on the terrace. It was just a fleeting glance and then I looked away. I lived on the third floor and the staircase was dark, except for a small night light. While I was opening my door, I felt someone breathing down my neck. I looked back but couldn't see anything. But I sensed there was someone standing there.

As soon as I entered my house, I switched on the light outside my home but deliberately did not put on any light within, and stood in a dark corner in the house from where I could view the area outside the iron gate. Just a few seconds later, this man came down the stairs, peered through the gate to see inside. I will never forget his face. I don't know how I spent the night in that house. The next day, I stayed over at a colleague's place and then flew to Mumbai to bring my parents back.

In another incident five years ago, it was one in the afternoon, when I was in my car and had halted at a traffic signal on a busy intersection. Two men on a scooter pulled up next to me. One of them got down and pretended to check his scooter, but actually yanked off the petrol tube from beneath my car. I immediately knew something was wrong. When the lights turned green, the car responded sluggishly. The two men came up behind

my car and told me to check the petrol pipe. I ignored them and pulled to a corner. Then one of them came up to my side and asked me to roll down the window. I refused. A few seconds later, the second man came up to the other side. They both tried to get me out of the car. I let them leave, before I got out to go to the petrol pump

SUNITHA NARAHARI, 45, SENIOR LAWYER, DELHI



REUBEN SINGH

to look for help. Since then, I have always kept an eye on the rear-view mirror. I check my surroundings, but there are times when you are distracted and don't pay attention. You hear about such things. You read about it. But you try not to let that fear win. Because then you can't be a professional.

as told to Chitra Subramanyam

"I did not register a complaint, scared it would give me a bad reputation."

PRAGATHI, 28, CALL CENTRE EXECUTIVE, CHENNAI

I have been working for a Chennai call centre as an administrator since 2004. I often work late nights and our company cab usually picks me up and drops me at home. In May 2006, I was the last person to be dropped home. It was 2 a.m. on Parrys Beach Road and the driver casually said he was taking a short cut. Not being too familiar with Chennai at that time, I hesitantly nodded to him. Though I was eager to get home soon, a slight doubt crept in my mind. The car entered one of the dimly-lit streets and stopped. The driver got down and said that there was some problem with the engine. Panic struck me. I suddenly remembered the alarm button inside the car, which is linked to our office control room. I put my hand on the alarm button just in case. The driver saw me, opened the door, pushed me on the seat and tried to prevent me from pushing the button. I did press the button, but was not sure if the alarm had been communicated. But fortunately, it had. The staff, who had heard me shouting on the alarm line, immediately notified the police. Somehow, I managed to run and stopped an autorickshaw, begging the driver to take me home. The police, meanwhile,

22-year-old BPO executive, Jyothi Kumari Chaudhary, was raped and murdered by a taxi driver and his accomplice.

November 2007

A Delhi University student was abducted from Dhaura Kuan and raped by four men in a moving car at night.

May 2005